

Art and the Truth

Martin Iver Jacobsen | August, 2026

To know the world, we seek the sciences; to know ourselves, we seek the arts.

Most of the time, perhaps, we have little need of them. We go about our days asking of art little more than pleasure, company or diversion. But then somebody dies; somebody breaks our heart; or, no less violently, we discover that we're in love. The experience which had existed until then merely as a word – grief, love, despair – becomes an actuality. We know it completely and yet we're quite unable to say what it is. Then, the arts cease to be ornaments of existence. We reach for a poem, put on a song, remember a passage from a novel, and we recognize, with something between gratitude and amazement, that a stranger who lived in another country or another century has said precisely what we thought or felt, but couldn't express, not even for ourselves.

In so doing, the artist doesn't abolish our solitude. For no experience is transferable from one consciousness to another. The feelings, however eloquently the artist describes them, belong only to the person who has felt them. But they have taken a form which we can comprehend. And we're reminded that the very things that torment us the most are what make us human. Art exposes the communion between solitudes.

When this happens, we invariably say that the piece of art is true. Not because it contains any facts that one would find in a physics textbook, but because it carries with it something truer than facts. It asks no effort of us, and returns what was always ours to know.

When Diogenes was shown the votive tablets of sailors who prayed and survived shipwreck, we are told that he responded, "Ay. I see those who were saved, but where are those painted who prayed and drowned?" These tablets, then, were not true. Truth demands the whole, and the whole embraces its contraries. There's no courage without fear; no virtue that has not been tempted; no delight in having someone to love without the risk of having someone to lose. The artist who refuses to explore both the good and the bad may give us saints and monsters, but will never give us a human being.

Caravaggio gave his own face to Goliath, but he did not give David the face of righteous satisfaction. The young victor holds the severed head before him and looks upon it almost sorrowfully. Here violence and compassion are in the same darkness; the man capable of bloodshed is also capable of pity, and the sinner can imagine himself both condemned and mourned. Other great artists might have divided the world cleanly between David and Goliath, between virtue and wickedness. But Caravaggio knew better. The line doesn't run between the victor and the vanquished. It runs through them.

Art cannot tell us why violence and pity coexist any more than science can tell us why gravity exists. But it can make us understand how a mother can love her child and resent what motherhood has cost her; how a dying man can weep for the fading light and welcome the eternal darkness; how a betrayed husband can hate a wife he cannot stop loving. The search for truth wears many faces – science, philosophy, religion – but nowhere does it come so near its object, and nowhere is the seeking so much its own reward, as in the arts.